

Collectible printing service

A practical El Segundo pilot, a Shopify order flow, and an open Printers Guild

Recommendation: begin as an outsourced collectible-printing service with local proofing and home packing. Launch one paper edition and one metal sample before taking a lease or buying production machinery. Sell craft, provenance and fulfillment; do not promise cash redemption, financial returns or official currency status.



Format sketches only. The rail motif is original placeholder geometry; these are not approved KansasDAO art or print-ready designs.

What the first service sells

NounsMoney and KansasDAO become a coherent family of collectible notes, lion/train souvenirs, medallions and art stamps. A customer can buy a finished edition or commission a small custom run. Optional Tezos twins are a separate, opt-in provenance layer after the physical workflow works.

Three decisions define a workable pilot

Product: use an original design, a flexible paper proof and a numbered edition. Confirm commercial rights to all supplied art, including the supplied lion and train imagery, before release.

Price: preserve the requested price of 2 x (estimated printing + estimated shipping), while showing the other costs separately.

Place: use El Segundo as the first pickup/event community; outsource production and prove repeat demand before taking premises.

Status: this is a blueprint, not a live store, vendor order, lease, payment setup or legal clearance. The Shopify store and access route remain to be confirmed. Prices below are public list references, not payable checkout totals.

How paper money is printed

US banknotes use a 75% cotton and 25% linen substrate, with specialist layered printing, raised intaglio ink, numbering and extensive quality inspection. The government substrate is restricted. Some other countries use polymer. These are industrial systems; a desktop printer alone does not reproduce their feel. [1, 2]

Translate the feel into an original collectible

Route	Good for	What to expect
Digital on uncoated text	First proofs and small editions	Flexible, economical-looking proof; smooth ink or toner rather than banknote relief
Cotton paper plus specialty finish	Premium tactile edition	Ask a specialist for compatible stock and letterpress, embossing or foil samples; quote required
Synthetic or translucent material	Experimental Guild edition	Test print compatibility, folding, abrasion and packing; do not call it banknote-grade polymer

Print the first proof near El Segundo

FedEx Office, 630 N Pacific Coast Hwy, El Segundo: the official location lists digital printing and finishing. Ask for a written quote for 10 duplex sheets, three original collectible designs per sheet, then 30 cut notes. Request flexible matte/uncoated stock, front/back alignment and one physical proof before the run. Specific stock, cutting tolerance, acceptance and price remain unconfirmed. [3]

CatPrint: a second sample route for specialty paper and foil. Its site advertises optional hard-copy proofs and foil with no order minimums. A stock name alone is not proof of banknote feel; request a paper sample and confirm the chosen weight, finish and process. No paper-job price is verified yet. [4]

Proof inspection

Check both faces in daylight; fold a sacrificial sample; rub it with a dry cloth; inspect trim, corner damage and ink adhesion. Photograph the accepted sample and record the stock and process. Digital color approval is not a physical material approval.

Keep the artwork recognizably fictional. A “not legal tender” statement alone does not make reproductions of genuine notes compliant. US currency illustrations have specific restrictions; have potentially confusing designs reviewed before publication. [5]

Launch catalog and cost evidence

Launch item	Specification to quote	Release gate
Paper note set	30 cut notes; original two-sided design; flexible stock	Physical proof, rights and actual quote
Lion or train medallion	Single metal sample, then optional 25-piece run	Approved relief proof and tested finish
Pressed-penny-style souvenir	Purpose-made elongated blank or specialist souvenir product	Separate quote; do not assume coin pricing covers a pressing machine
Art stamp sheet	Printed collectible labels for albums	Clear NOT POSTAGE label; no placement on outgoing mail
Rubber stamp	Separate carving or photopolymer tool	Ink/material test and custom quote

Public metal price references

Supplier and option	Qty	Production incl mold	Per piece
Etched in Ashes double-sided	1	From \$34.99	\$34.99+
CC4L 1.5 in plain	25	\$276.00	\$11.04
CC4L 1.5 in one-face color	25	\$284.00	\$11.36
CC4L 1.5 in plain	100	\$444.00	\$4.44
CC4L 1.5 in one-face color	100	\$474.00	\$4.74

Etched in Ashes lists no minimum; the \$34.99 figure is a starting price and shipping is unknown. CC4L totals are calculated from its public unit prices plus a \$100 mold; advertised contiguous-US shipping is included. Confirm design, metal, finish, tax, lead time, tooling ownership, replacements and delivered total before ordering. [6, 7]

These are medallion/challenge-coin references, not circulating coins or verified prices for penny-press equipment. Genuine postage must be bought through authorized postage channels; a collectible stamp is not postage. USPS rules also restrict imitations on mail. [8]

Production and fulfillment workflow

One job record from request to delivery

- 1. Intake.** Record customer, delivery country, quantity, material, dimensions, sides, artwork version, rights declaration, deadline and budget. Keep billing data inside the payment provider. Collect only the data needed to complete the job.
- 2. Preflight.** Check legibility, margins, resolution, two-sided orientation and the supplier template. Remove unsupported financial or postage claims. Separate customer artwork from production files; keep revision names stable.
- 3. Quote.** Obtain print, setup/tooling, inbound and outbound freight, applicable tax, packaging and lead-time details. A quote expires when its supplier price expires. Define whether the service price covers a whole batch or individual pieces.
- 4. Proof approval.** Share a numbered digital proof and, for new material or process, a physical sample. Customer approves the exact version, dimensions, material and disclosed tolerances. Any later change creates a new version and, if needed, a new quote.
- 5. Payment and release.** Invoice the approved specification. Check that payment succeeded and the order is not on hold before placing the production order. Never treat an emailed screenshot as proof of payment.
- 6. Quality and dispatch.** Count accepted items, record damaged/rejected pieces, verify edition numbers, photograph the lot and pack with a material/provenance card. Create tracking and close the job only after dispatch is verified.

Proposed service promises to approve before launch

Specify a proof-revision allowance and a clear cutoff for custom cancellation. Offer correction or replacement when work differs from the approved proof; distinguish that from customer-approved artwork mistakes. Publish a realistic production window with shipping separate, a defect-report route, and how delays will be handled. These are policy proposals, not existing customer terms.

Operational safeguards

Keep one retained sample per edition; never reuse a serial number for an undisclosed replacement. Log destruction or permanent marking of rejects. Grant production partners only job-specific files. Retain customer files for a stated period and then remove them under the published policy.

Pricing without hidden assumptions

Your requested rule: job price = 2 x (estimated printing + estimated shipping). If that base is \$36, the price is \$72: a 100% markup and 50% margin against that limited cost base. It is not a 50% net profit margin.

Illustrative batch of 30 notes	USD	Status
Printing / shipping	\$30 / \$6	Assumptions, not quotes
Requested selling price	\$72.00	2 x (\$30 + \$6)
Packaging / labor / spoilage	\$3 / \$15 / \$3	Assumptions
Payment fee at 2.9% + \$0.30	\$2.39	Illustrative fee, verify store
Contribution after those costs	\$12.61	Before overhead and income tax
Contribution as share of price	17.5%	Not 50%

This example is one batch sold in one transaction. Selling 30 notes separately would require per-order packaging, outbound shipping and payment fees. If the displayed product price already includes shipping, do not add the same shipping cost again at checkout.

A separate optional all-in price

For an independently chosen 35% contribution-margin target, use (all non-percentage variable costs + fixed payment fee) / (1 - payment rate - target margin). In this example: $(\$57 + \$0.30) / (1 - 0.029 - 0.35) = \textbf{\$92.28 per batch}$ rounded up to cents. This is a comparison, not a replacement for your 2x rule.

Tooling and taxes need explicit treatment

A first coin run can carry a substantial one-time mold fee. Put it in the quote as tooling or explicitly include it in estimated production; do not hide it. Separate freight to the service from freight to the customer. Sales tax collected is generally not sales revenue; unrecoverable procurement tax belongs in costs. Verify actual treatment with a qualified adviser.

The companion workbook keeps quoted reference prices separate from editable planning assumptions and calculates price, contribution and overhead break-even. Shopify subscription, apps, refunds, chargebacks and owner time beyond the modeled labor can lower actual profit further.

Shopify from creation to payment

Use two paths: normal checkout for finished, stocked editions; quote-first invoicing for bespoke jobs. Shopify draft orders support invoice checkout, custom items and manual order creation. This blueprint does not presume that the store is connected or configured. [9]

Stage	Store design	Operational check
Catalog	Separate paper, medallion, art-stamp and custom-job products	Keep every item in draft until rights and specs pass
Options	Material, edition and pack quantity; custom fields for other details	Do not create a giant matrix of impossible combinations
Artwork	Secure approved upload app or quoted intake route	Virus checks, access controls, retention and version ID
Quote and proof	Draft order plus proof-version reference	Customer approves art and landed price before payment
Payment	Invoice links to Shopify checkout	Verify paid state; no manual card-data collection
Production	Tag job as paid and approved, then release to supplier	Never print automatically on an unreviewed file
Shipping and support	Tracking, delivery updates and published defect policy	Log replacements/refunds and reconcile costs

Shopify supports up to three product options; apps or line-item properties can handle additional customization. Choose an upload route only after reviewing its permissions, price and customer-data handling. A catalog CSV can carry product records but will not create proof approval, secure uploads or the entire custom workflow. [10]

Avoid long authorization holds. Shopify Payments normally has a seven-day authorization period. For artwork that may take weeks, approve the quote and proof first, then invoice; do not rely on capture remaining available indefinitely. Payment methods and plans can differ. [11]

Before launch: confirm store URL and owner; business identity and payment eligibility; shipping zones and profiles; tax settings; notification copy; refund terms; test checkout and failed-payment handling. Shopify US Basic is publicly listed at \$39/month on monthly billing; rates and offers are locale-specific, and apps can cost extra. No subscription is authorized by this plan. [12]

An open Printers Guild

Make the Guild an open practice community and public quality specification. Anyone can learn, submit a sample and publish a process record. Membership should not imply government endorsement, financial backing, exclusive licensing or guaranteed authenticity.

Minimum standard for a Guild-listed edition

Clear identity. Name the artist, printer and issuer accurately; state “collectible / no cash value / not legal tender” where relevant, and “not postage” on art stamps. Do not make unverified affiliation claims.

Rights record. Keep the design source, license and permission evidence for the commercial edition. Ownership of a digital token or physical object does not automatically grant copyright.

Material and process record. Name the substrate, approximate dimensions, printing/engraving method, finish, edition size and production date. Verify recycled, archival, precious-metal or sustainability claims before using them.

Repeatable quality. Publish a sample, legibility and trim criteria, acceptable color/finish variation, and a defect policy. Use an edition/job identifier; numbering is provenance, not anti-counterfeit certainty.

Honest edition accounting. Record issued pieces, artist proofs, rejects and replacements. Publicly document changes to an edition. Verification is opt-in; the Guild mark refers to a disclosed checklist, not a regulated credential.

Materials worth testing

Material or finish	Interesting property	Test before a paid edition
Cotton or recycled text	Soft or visibly fibrous surface	Feeding, folding and ink adhesion
Kozo or handmade paper	Visible fibers and irregular edges	Legibility, handling and repeatability
Foil or translucent vellum	Light and layering	Scuffing, show-through and packing
Brass, copper or anodized metal	Weight, patina and tactile relief	Sharp edges, finish wear and truthful composition

Optional Tezos twins should link to the approved edition record without publishing customer addresses or private files. Explain what the token does and does not confer. Do not require a wallet to buy the physical edition or promise token value. Minting, wallet activity and any token sale need separate scope and review.

El Segundo operating model

Model	Illustrative fixed cost / month	When it makes sense
Home packing plus outsource	\$100	Pilot; no new production press or lease
Shared studio	\$1,200	Recurring paid work needs space or shared tools
Dedicated shop	\$6,000	Predictable demand pays for staffed premises

These are deliberately editable scenario inputs, not local rent quotes or complete budgets. They exclude buildout, deposits, insurance surprises, compliance work and capital equipment unless added. No premises have been identified as available, and no lease or purchase is proposed.

At the illustrative \$12.61 batch contribution, the three fixed-cost cases require roughly **8, 96 or 476 batches per month** to break even, before any other omitted costs. At 30 notes per batch, a storefront therefore implies substantial throughput. Replace the example with real quotes and observed labor before deciding.

A lean El Segundo pilot

Use the local FedEx Office for proof discussion, a qualified specialty supplier for the premium sample, and a permitted home packing area. Host a small demonstration or pickup session only after the venue and relevant permissions are confirmed. A lion/train edition can introduce the process, then customer commissions can test repeat demand.

Launch gates rather than calendar promises

Gate 1: approve one original design and verify rights. Set collectible-only claims.

Gate 2: receive paper and metal samples, actual delivered quotes and production timelines.

Gate 3: approve a price policy, custom cancellation/defect terms and shipping method.

Gate 4: configure and test the confirmed Shopify store, including proof-to-payment handoff.

Gate 5: deliver a small paid edition, record real labor/waste/defects, and decide whether to repeat.

What to decide next

Choose the first paper finish and batch quantity; confirm who owns the artwork rights; identify the Shopify store; and set a sample-order spending limit. Actual printing, publishing, payments, vendor communications, contracts and premises commitments remain separate actions.

Use “collectible printing studio” or “Printers Guild” for public operating descriptions. Any plan involving deposits, redeemable balances, circulating currency or financial services needs a separate legal and operational review.

Sources and verification notes

Primary references checked 02 October 2026. Availability, final tax, delivery and checkout totals were not verified.

[1] US Bureau of Engraving and Printing - How money is made

<https://www.bep.gov/currency/how-money-is-made>

[2] Bank of England - Why new banknotes are made of polymer

<https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/explainers/why-are-new-banknotes-made-of-polymer>

[3] FedEx Office - El Segundo location and services

<https://local.fedex.com/en-us/ca/el-segundo/office-1012>

[4] CatPrint - Products, foil and hard-copy proofs

<https://www.catprint.com/>

[5] US Bureau of Engraving and Printing - Currency image use restrictions

<https://www.bep.gov/currency/currency-image-use>

[6] Etched in Ashes - Current custom coin catalog

<https://www.etchedinashes.com/shop>

[7] ChallengeCoins4Less - Coin unit pricing, mold fees and shipping

<https://www.challengecoins4less.com/coin-pricing>

[8] USPS Postal Explorer - DMM 604 postage payment methods

<https://pe.usps.com/text/dmm300/604.htm>

[9] Shopify Help Center - Draft orders and invoices

<https://help.shopify.com/en/manual/fulfillment/managing-orders/create-orders>

[10] Shopify Help Center - Adding variants and customization options

<https://help.shopify.com/en/manual/products/variants/add-variants>

[11] Shopify Help Center - Payment authorization and capture

<https://help.shopify.com/en/manual/payments/payment-authorization>

[12] Shopify - Plans and pricing, locale-dependent

<https://www.shopify.com/pricing>

How to use this evidence

Public list prices establish a comparison baseline. A signed or accepted supplier quote must resolve specifications, quantity, taxes, freight, lead time and remedies before a customer price becomes a firm promise. The financial scenarios, Guild standard, operating workflow and launch gates are recommendations developed for this plan, not vendor guarantees.